

INTERVIEW: NAWAZ SHARIF

"Zardari has not spoken to me for over two

A day after he came up trumps in his stand-off with the Asif Zardari Government over the deposed judges, Nawaz Sharif was busy in political deliberations and rallies. Only at midnight was he able to speak to INDIA TODAY Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA over phone from Lahore about how he saw the political developments and the future of Pakistan. Excerpts:

Q. What was the tipping point that made the Zardari Government capitulate and restore the deposed Supreme Court chief justice?

A. It was peoples' power. The struggle has been going on for two years now, ever since Musharraf had fired the chief justice—an act that made him extremely unpopular. I feel proud that the Government felt compelled to reverse the decision because of peoples' power. History is being written.

Q. Wasn't the rapprochement because of US pressure? What did US Secretary of State Hillary Clinton tell you?

A. There was no pressure from the US. The American role was positive and they were sympathetic. They felt disturbed that the Opposition and the Government had fallen apart and expressed a desire that we should be working together—nothing more and nothing else.

Q. Was it also the threat of an army takeover that made Zardari yield? What role did General Kayani play in all this?

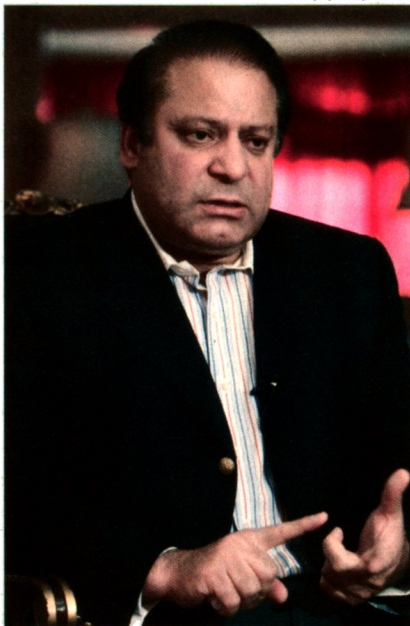
A. I don't think the army wanted to take power or will do so. General Kayani's role has been typical of a professional soldier and I am sure he doesn't have any political intentions. He is a decent man and doesn't want to get involved in politics at all.

Q. Is it not a defining moment for

Pakistan that the army had an excuse to seize power but didn't?

A. The struggle to restore the independence of the judiciary inspired a lot of confidence in the people. Today, there is a presence of a strong political leadership in Pakistan, a leadership that wants to play a positive role and put the country back on the rails and set the system completely right. So it minimises the chances and prospects of any extra-constitutional action in the country.

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Q. Would there now be better relations between your party and the Zardari Government?

A. We could have stated that apart from the judges' issue, we will call off the Long March to Islamabad only if

governor's rule was withdrawn in Punjab and the court order disqualifying me and Shahbaz Sharif from contesting be reversed. But we felt the judges' issue was of national importance and called off the Long March when the Government agreed to restore the deposed judges. So I congratulated the prime minister and the President. I also spoke to the prime minister and we decided to move forward on the charter of democracy that the late Benazir Bhutto and I had agreed upon.

Q. What does the charter of democracy entail?

A. It means repealing all the controversial amendments of the Constitution brought in by Musharraf—essentially the 17th Amendment—and also the appointment of judges of the Supreme Court and the high courts through a commission, among many other things.

Q. Do you see your party rejoining the ruling coalition?

A. I don't see that happening in the foreseeable future. We would not like to destabilise the Government and we are not demanding immediate elections in the country. Our agenda is clear—we respect their mandate and they must respect ours. We want to work together with the prime minister to strengthen the democratic system in the country. Like your country we have a parliamentary democracy and we want the prime minister to run the show. In our Constitution, like in yours, the President is only a constitutional head and the chief executive is the prime minister.

"WE WANT PRIME MINISTER GILANI TO RUN THE SHOW. THE PRESIDENT IS ONLY A CONSTITUTIONAL HEAD, NOT THE CEO."